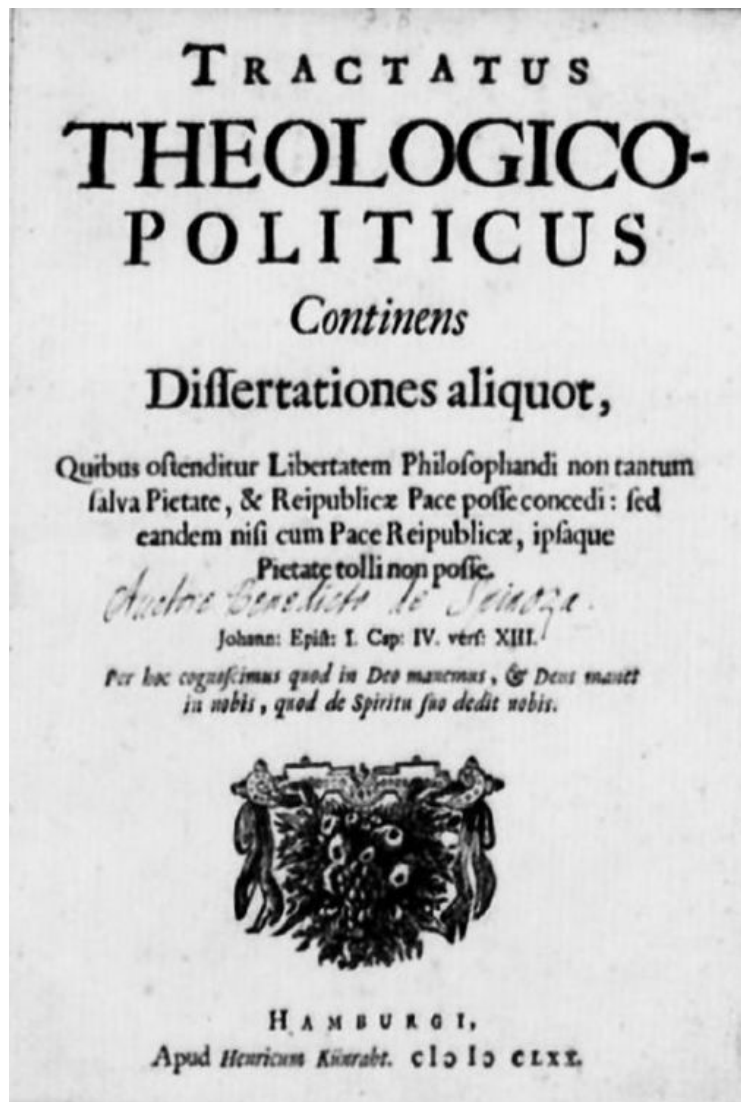


Spinoza: God and nature



Spinoza was a profoundly religious man and was concerned that little place was given to God in the increasingly mechanistic interpretation of the universe, other than as its creator. He believed that God is not separate from the world, any more than the mental and physical are separate, and that God is infinite and all-pervasive, so there cannot be anything that God is not – he is not outside the world, nor is he in it, but he *is* the world. God, for Spinoza, is the one substance that constitutes the world and has both physical and mental properties, so our religious, philosophical and scientific conceptions of it are simply different aspects of the same reality. Everything

that exists is composed of the same substance, so the universe, or nature, and God are the same thing. This belief that God and nature are identical – pantheism – became influential in the Romantic movement (see [Idealism and nature](#)), but Spinoza's beliefs were seen at the time as tantamount to atheism: he was excommunicated from the synagogue and his *Tractatus Theologico-Politicus* was banned by the Church.